

« Sometimes, you swim at a high stroke rate, thinking the faster you pull, the faster you'll swim, but that's not true »

SRIHARI NATARAJ

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Srihari Nataraj caused a ripple effect as he clinched a silver medal in the men's 200m freestyle event on the opening day of the 11th Asian Aquatics Championships, held at the Veer Savarkar Sports Complex in Naranpura, Gujarat, from September 28 to October 10.

It was India's first medal at the continental event in 16 years. The host nation eventually finished with its best-ever haul of 13 medals in a single edition — four silver and nine bronze — and the 24-year-old from Bengaluru played a huge role in that success, with four individual medals and three in relays.

In an exclusive conversation with *Sportstar*, Srihari opened up about his preparation, the use of data to improve his results, and more:

Did you know before this event that India hadn't won a medal for 16 years?

I knew we didn't win a medal at the previous one in 2016. I did the qualifying time (during the trials), but I came third. Then, one of my seniors, who came second, said he wasn't going to swim the 200m backstroke. He said he'd inform the federation so that I'd get the spot, but I didn't. I didn't know it had been 16 years — it wasn't on my mind.

How did you prepare for the event?

It was a good month in Ahmedabad under coach Nihar Ameen. I like to stay at home and train, but we had the camp. The facility was really good.

I did miss some of Mum's food and the way she pampers me before sessions with a milkshake. She even jokingly told someone that maybe the difference between gold and silver in some of the events was the smoothies and the stuff she keeps ready for me before or after my sessions.

Out of the seven medals you won, which one was the toughest, and in which did you feel you had the best chance of winning gold?

If I had swum just the 50m backstroke, it would have been a lot closer than it was. That was definitely an event where I thought I could get gold. [The gap between Srihari and China's Gukailai Wang, the gold medallist, was 0.35 seconds]

Going into the 100m backstroke final, I was the fastest seed, and I hadn't swum the 100m backstroke for a medal this entire year, or even in a final. I thought I might surprise myself — and at 75m, I did surprise myself — but physically, that was a tough race for me.

How did data analytics help you in your training and races?

I've been working with Swimple, a company that analyses races, for a long time. It's based at the Padukone-Dravid Centre for Sports Excellence, where I train.